Whether you want to consider data products as a platform feature as well is your choice. There is no right or wrong answer to this question, but you should at least have one answer that you base your work on. So now let's see why we are choosing to consider data products as part of the platform for our MVP.

7.1.2 Platform thinking

To understand the idea behind platform thinking, we find it easier to use a nonsoftware example. Imagine a woodworking shop. A bunch of woodworkers share the space. It also has an owner who provisions everything. Multiple people are using saws, hammers, chisels, and various power tools to make furniture.

What usually happens in woodworking is that people start to make a few customized tools. That could be a simple dovetail guardrail; it could be a special chisel or a carving tool. The woodworkers need these in their development process because the alternative is to make a piece less perfect and spend a lot of time doing harder work.

Now, the workshop owner could just buy a bunch of special-purpose tools. But to truly make this useful, he would need a huge inventory of them and a decent catalog to find the right tool.

Instead, he could provide something else: a special station for making special-purpose tools, including a few measurement instruments, a drawing board, possibly some metalworking instruments, and the like. Additionally, he could organize a short meetup on Wednesday evenings to let people showcase their special-purpose tools.

What the workshop owner would be utilizing as an alternative to stocking a lot of specialist tools is *product thinking*—providing people with the tools they need. In the second alternative, however, he is leveraging another idea called *platform thinking*.

The workshop owner is providing a platform: the special-purpose tool station that enables others via self-service to easily increase their output flow of high-quality furniture. He is utilizing the analysis of the flow of work, the